

Money Mistake: *Your Drug Use Is “Recreational”*

The Fix: *You Can’t Afford a Drug Addiction—Period.*

It can be easy to justify. You’ve got it under control, right? You’re not an addict. I’m going to shoot straight with you: messing around with drugs is never worth it, for lots of reasons. But the financial impact on the rest of your life will be colossal.

Drugs cost money—money that could be going into your Secret 10. Then there’s the cost of addiction. No one ever thinks they’re going to become addicted. *No one.* That means every single addict out there was once a kid just like you, saying, “I’m not going to get hooked.” And what do you know? They got hooked! I hope I don’t have to tell you how devastating drug addiction can be to your future, not to mention your future relationships. Drugs erode the entire foundation of your partnership.

Look, I’m no saint. I experimented with drugs when I was young. I also saw the damage it did to the people around me. I watched a couple of close friends go off the rails at an early age. One of them got involved in dealing and ultimately went to prison. It ruined his life forever. Another guy did so many drugs that it permanently affected his personality and he became mentally unstable.

People tend to forget the indirect costs of using; you don’t have to be a full-fledged addict to pay the price. Tony was a friend of mine at university, a nice enough guy who liked to smoke up occasionally. One night, Tony was driving a little too fast and got pulled over. His eyes were bloodshot, which made the officer suspicious. She opened the glove compartment and found 30 grams of marijuana in a small plastic bag. Tony was fined \$1,000 and charged with minor possession. A first-time conviction can result in up to six months of jail time, so Tony got off easy with just a fine.

But the story doesn’t end there. Minor possession of small amounts of marijuana is a summary offense—less serious than an indictable offense, but it still gets entered in the criminal justice system. The court kept a record of Tony’s conviction, which would follow him around *for the rest of his life*. He got rejected for every